The Political Bugbears

As chief minister, Fadnavis could face a challenge managing Shinde and his Sena, who may have trouble reconciling to a secondary role. Much of the optics will depend on how the BJP and Fadnavis can use Ajit and his NCP as a counter-weight to Shinde, and vice versa. The poll results have come as a new lease of life for Ajit, who was almost written off before the election. But the BJP also needs to tread with caution as it plays the two. The Shinde Sena's seven Lok Sabha MPs will be crucial when it has to push through crucial legislation in Parliament. Any slighting of Shinde also risks undermining the BJP's 'Project Shiv Sena', where it seeks to decimate the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray).

As expected, his partymen did not take well to Shinde being passed over for CM. "This is bad for the alliance and the party," claims a Sena legislator. "It's also a setback for the Shiv Sena in the local body elections and has given the SS(UBT) a chance to revive itself." Another source in the Shiv Sena was upset that the 'turnaround man'—for hadn't he led the Mahayuti to success after the drubbing in the Lok Sabha election?—had been denied his due. "Shinde is not chair-hungry...the issue is about respecting the mandate and offering an honourable deal," he says. The fear now is that the BJP may assert itself over Shinde's choices too. The party is said to have had reservations about some Sena ministers in the last cabinet. There are also some who wonder whether Shinde's belligerence in the run-up to the formation of the government was because he had the backing of some entities in the BJP's central leadership, as a counterweight to Fadnavis.

However, a senior legislator from western Maharashtra claims that much of Shinde's actions were "optics meant for his supporters". Based on the premise that he would be back at the helm, Shinde is said to have promised ministerial berths and other perks to many partymen, and these actions will show he fought hard to try and get them their due. "Shinde would have never become CM had he stayed on with Uddhav Thackeray. The BJP gave him the opportunity," points out a BJP legislator.

Then there is the crucial question of quotas for the dominant Marathas. In the Lok Sabha election, the Mahayuti parties had lost seven out of the eight seats in the Marathwada region, largely due to Maratha consolidation amid protests for the community to be accommodated within the Other Backward Classes (OBC) category. It didn't work in the assembly poll due to majoritarian assertion and the counter-consolidation of the OBCs for the Mahayuti, besides the new welfare schemes that appealed to all sections being one cause for the splintering of the Maratha vote. Maratha activist Manoj Jarange-Patil, Fadnavis's bugbear, has threatened to launch a fresh agitation. The state government will have to ensure its 10 per cent ring-fenced Maratha quota stands the test in the courts. The BJP will also be under pressure to accommodate the demands of the OBC Dhangars for inclusion in the Scheduled Tribes (ST) list, something the tribals have opposed.

More crucially, as a senior BJP leader noted, Fadnavis and the BJP will have to meet the aspirations of legislators across party lines for cabinet berths. Faced with a problem of plenty, they are sure to upset a few fragile egos. BJP loyalists and those with a background in the Sangh Parivar are already cross at being passed over in favour of newer entrants in the party. With the RSS playing a major role in grassroots mobilisation for the BJP, these old-timers will want recompense.

Fadnavis also faces a stiff challenge on the economic front. Economist Ajit Ranade's must-do list: "Accelerating growth to attain the aspiration of being a $1 trillion economy, with a rise in GDP, employment, investments and exports, while also managing the challenges of urbanisation and the environment." All that, while bearing the dual burden of "long-term debt (and) populist schemes". The Mahayuti had promised to upscale Ladki Bahin's monthly dole to Rs 2,100 for an intended 25 million beneficiaries. This will spike the scheme's annual outlay from Rs 46,000 crore to Rs 63,000 crore. The state's entire bouquet of populist schemes will cost the exchequer Rs 90,000 crore annually. Questions are already being asked on how it will balance those with infrastructure needs. Fadnavis will have to be a deft economic juggler while walking a political tightrope. ■

FADNAVIS'S CHALLENGES



A NEW DAY Fadnavis, Shinde and Pawar at Raj Bhavan in Mumbai after staking claim to form the government, Dec. 4

POLITICAL

- Striking a balance between party and its two smaller allies
- Using NCP, Shiv Sena as counterweight against each other
- Confronting any resurgence of the Maratha protests
- Meeting demands of groups like the OBC Dhangars for inclusion in the tribal quota without upsetting the latter

ECONOMIC

- Accelerating growth to become a $1 trillion economy
- Meeting the high costs of populist schemes like Ladki Bahin
- Development of backward regions like Marathwada
- Overcoming agrarian distress
- Managing urbanisation and environmental challenges